

Chapter 10 - Pink Bubbles

Ning Fuyi blinked, and that string of words disappeared, leaving only what appeared to be an ordinary flower petal on the table.

What was Chu Qingqiu trying to do? Could it be that she had discovered the incident of Ning Fuyi stumbling upon her injury that day, so she wanted to threaten her secretly? The more Ning Fuyi thought about it, the more she shivered.

No, this matter was suspicious. She must not fall for it.

Ning Fuyi snorted and raised her hand to brush away the flower petal.

After ignoring this interlude, Ning Fuyi finally raised her head to look around. She saw that all the disciples had already seated themselves properly. The hall was packed with heads of people, while Chu Qingqiu stood at the entrance, seemingly waiting for something.

Li Chao'an and her two lackeys sat to Ning Fuyi's right. Li Chao'an had already washed off the soot from her face, but the missing corner of her hair couldn't be restored temporarily, so she used a tasseled hairpin from her forehead to cover it.

She was currently staring at Ning Fuyi with wide eyes. Ning Fuyi was too lazy to pay attention to her and continued lying on the table with her eyes closed, resting.

After a while, the sound of messy footsteps came from outside the hall. Feeling Liu Wenzhu beside her straighten up, Ning Fuyi finally opened her eyes and saw three elders entering - all except the Chief Elder.

They were Elder Pingyao, Elder Jingshan (the male elder from that day), and Perfected Being Yuanming, who was younger and had just returned from Zhaoyao Mountain today.

After the three of them entered, they first paid their respects to Chu Qingqiu.

So Ning Fuyi let out a light snort through her nose. Although others couldn't hear it, she still had to display this attitude of disapproval.

Then Mei Chengsi entered, and Ning Fuyi snorted even louder. This time it attracted sideways glances from a group of disciples, including glares from the two sect masters and several elders.

"Quiet." Elder Pingyao said sternly. She moved her gaze away from Ning Fuyi, her tone authoritative. "Why don't you quickly pay respects to the sect master?"

The disciples hadn't yet adapted to the change of sect master. Reminded by Elder Pingyao, they finally stood up one after another, bowing toward the entrance and saying in unison: "Greetings to the Sect Master."

Compared to Mei Chengsi beside her, who was glowing and holding his head high, Chu Qingqiu appeared somewhat indifferent, only nodding slightly to indicate that everyone should sit down.

"There have been many changes in the sect recently. We know everyone is grieving, but the Zhaoyao Grand Assembly¹ is approaching. This matter is crucial for Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, so you all need to collect your thoughts and give your all, to comfort the spirit of the former sect master in heaven." Elder Pingyao sighed deeply and continued, "The North Courtyard disciples have shallow cultivation and do not yet possess magical artifacts, so normally they wouldn't be qualified to participate in the Zhaoyao Grand Assembly. However, this time the Zhaoyao Grand Assembly has specially established competitions for disciples at the Clear Realm² and below, so you cannot stay out of it either. You must cultivate diligently."

"Therefore, today we need to test everyone's spell systems³ for organization, to prepare for selecting candidates later. No one is allowed to be absent." After Elder Pingyao finished speaking, she turned her palm, and a jade sundial appeared in her palm, falling to the ground and gradually growing larger.

Finally, it grew to the height of a person before stopping its expansion.

Looking at this Sacred Heavenly Sundial⁴ that they rarely saw on ordinary days, the disciples immediately became excited, quickly forgetting about other matters and beginning to whisper among themselves, making the hall somewhat noisy for a while.

Even Liu Wenzhu visibly became somewhat excited. She gently tugged at Ning Fuyi's sleeve and whispered, "Yiyi, that's the once-in-a-century Zhaoyao Grand Assembly. Are you really not interested?"

"No." Ning Fuyi shook her head. She was bored and tapped the table edge. Leaving aside whether she was interested or not, just with her level of cultivation, how could Elder Pingyao possibly let her participate? If other sects saw this and laughed at them, it would be Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate losing face.

"Don't worry, with your talent, there's absolutely no problem." Ning Fuyi comforted Liu Wenzhu.

She knew Liu Wenzhu had been looking forward to the Zhaoyao Grand Assembly for a long time, and she also knew she was absolutely qualified. Liu Wenzhu was the eldest daughter of the Liu family, one of the largest cultivation families. She had been given high expectations by her family since childhood, so she always wanted to distinguish herself early to not disappoint her family's expectations.

Liu Wenzhu held Ning Fuyi's hand, looking at her with heartache.

"What's the use of her wanting it?" Li Chao'an across the aisle suddenly spoke up, raising her chin. "It's not like we haven't used the Sacred Heavenly Sundial before. She can't even detect what spell system she has. After cultivating for more than twenty years, her cultivation is still at the Initial Realm⁵. Let her go? That would embarrass my adoptive mother and our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate."

"Li Chao'an." Liu Wenzhu slammed her delicate hand on the table, immediately creating a crack in the stone table, nearly causing Ning Fuyi to fall off the bench.

"What? I'm just telling the truth." Li Chao'an tilted her head with a shallow smile.

"Wenzhu." Ning Fuyi stopped Liu Wenzhu, who was about to continue arguing with her, and turned to look Li Chao'an up and down, examining her from head to toe, then looking back bit by bit.

In her previous life, she had many bad reputations, and her favorite description of herself was "killing without blinking an eye." Although she didn't have the opportunity now, she could plan for the future - how to kill her was still somewhat difficult.

Should she directly set her on fire, or throw her into the River of Three Paths⁶ to feed that turtle that had cultivated into a spirit in the cesspit?

Although Li Chao'an didn't know what Ning Fuyi was thinking, she felt her scalp go numb from being looked at with that predatory gaze, involuntarily backing away, her mocking words also getting stuck.

Anger burned in her heart. She had always been superior to Ning Fuyi - when had she ever been at a disadvantage in front of her? Now she was intimidated by just a look - what sense did that make?

So she was about to mock her a few more times when Elder Pingyao at the front suddenly spoke, her eyes looking directly this way, her words a warning: "The sect master is present. No noise allowed!"

Li Chao'an quickly shut her mouth, biting her lip to appear well-behaved, while Ning Fuyi also withdrew her murderous intent, sitting properly with eyes on her nose and nose on her heart.

While they had undercurrents surging on this side, a disciple at the front had already been called by name. One by one, they stepped forward, pricked their palms, and dripped blood onto the sundial pointer. As soon as the blood touched the pointer, it would immediately disappear, and then the sundial would become like a mirror, displaying the disciple's immortal power level and spell system.

Generally speaking, cultivation levels were divided into nine realms: Initial Realm, Mortal Realm, Rising Realm, Clear Realm, Transformation Realm, Immortal Body Realm, Void Comprehension Realm, Great Vehicle Realm, and True God Realm⁷. Even the four great elders were only at Void Comprehension Realm. People in the entire cultivation world with cultivation above Void Comprehension could be counted on one's fingers.

Even Ning Changfeng was only at the high level of Great Vehicle Realm, while legend said Chu Qingqiu had broken through Great Vehicle to reach True God, but since Chu Qingqiu never concerned herself with worldly affairs before, the world only knew that the Divine Venerable's cultivation was unfathomably deep, with no one knowing if the rumors were true or false.

Besides this, each person's immortal power also had classifications of the five systems: Wind, Thunder, Water, Fire, and Wood⁸. Among people of the same realm, those with different spell systems also differed in strength. Fire and Thunder were primarily for combat power and were the strongest, Water and Wood were primarily for healing and thus secondary, while Wind was unremarkable and commonly acknowledged as the weakest.

Of course, except for Chu Qingqiu - she was the only one who could use Wind system spells to defeat all other spell system practitioners of equal cultivation level.

However, not everyone was Chu Qingqiu, and the most suitable spell system for each person could only be determined after breaking through to Mortal Realm. The disciples of the North Courtyard had entered late and hadn't been tested yet, so everyone was nervous now, hoping to possess stronger spell systems.

"Disciple Shuishui⁹." Rong Jin called out while holding the roster. A plump girl nervously ran forward and extended her hand to drip blood.

Although there was no sunlight, the shadow of the sundial pointer suddenly began to turn, stopping on a character, then the sundial became a mirror surface with xiyan flowers¹⁰ blooming profusely.

Each person's immortal power was different, so the specific scenes displayed were also different.

"Mortal Realm, Wood." Rong Jin announced loudly. The girl breathed a sigh of relief, covered her face, and ran back to her seat.

People went forward one by one, some happy and some worried, and for a while the surroundings were filled with long and short sighs.

"Li Chao'an." Rong Jin called out.

Hearing her name, Li Chao'an stood up, walking past Ning Fuyi with her head held high and chest out, her skirt flowing like clouds behind her. She stood before the Sacred Heavenly Sundial without the slightest hesitation and dripped a drop of blood.

The Sacred Heavenly Sundial also gave face by instantly reacting, with dazzling lightning appearing in the mirror surface.

"Clear Realm, Thunder." Rong Jin said.

As soon as these words were spoken, the other disciples immediately buzzed with discussion, all extremely envious. To possess Clear Realm cultivation at such a young age, and with the most powerful Thunder system for combat - how could this not make people envious?

Several elders also cast satisfied looks at her.

On her way back to her seat, Li Chao'an kept staring at Ning Fuyi. The moment Ning Fuyi looked up, she smugly curled up the corners of her mouth and said something with her lips. Although it was inaudible, it definitely wasn't anything good.

Before Ning Fuyi could counterattack, Rong Jin spoke again, calling out her name. The gazes of the others also instantly focused on her, with continuous whispers spreading.

Everyone knew Ning Fuyi had no talent. After cultivating for more than ten years, she was still at Initial Realm. Now testing her spell system in public was just providing entertainment for others to laugh at.

Ning Fuyi paused for a moment, then stood up, brushing past Li Chao'an and hearing her low snicker.

She was already used to this kind of public humiliation from her previous life, so she didn't feel much about it now. She casually made a cut on her hand.

Blood flowed from her palm and steadily dripped onto the pointer.

As expected, the pointer didn't move at all, and the sundial surface showed no changes. Ning Fuyi heard several suppressed laughs. She shrugged and was about to walk back.

Li Chao'an had already returned to her seat and was currently looking at her smugly with her chin up and through her nostrils. However, the next second, she moved her gaze away and became dumbfounded.

"Yiyi, Yiyi, look quickly!" Liu Wenzhu also suddenly stood up, pointing behind Ning Fuyi, her small face flushed with excitement into a light peach pink.

Ning Fuyi didn't know what was happening. With a confused expression, she turned around, only to be stunned by the scene before her eyes.

Amidst a chorus of gasps, she saw the pointer begin to slowly rotate. At the same time, the huge sundial surface turned into a mirror, and gurgles of...

Delicate pink bubbles began emerging!

Footnotes:

¹ Zhaoyao Grand Assembly (招摇大会) - A major cultivation world gathering/competition held once per century

² Clear Realm (明境) - The fourth level in the cultivation hierarchy

³ Spell systems (术系) - The five elemental categories of magical techniques: Wind, Thunder, Water, Fire, and Wood

⁴ Sacred Heavenly Sundial (圣天晷) - A magical artifact used to test cultivation levels and spell affinities

⁵ Initial Realm (初境) - The first and lowest level of cultivation

⁶ River of Three Paths (三途川) - A mythical river in Chinese folklore, similar to the River Styx

⁷ The nine cultivation realms from lowest to highest: Initial Realm (初境), Mortal Realm (凡境), Rising Realm (起境), Clear Realm (明境), Transformation Realm (化境), Immortal Body Realm (仙身), Void Comprehension Realm (通虚), Great Vehicle Realm (大乘), True God Realm (真神)

⁸ The five spell systems: Wind (风), Thunder (雷), Water (水), Fire (火), Wood (木)

⁹ Shuishui (水水) - A nickname meaning "Water-water," likely referencing her spell affinity

¹⁰ Xiyan flowers (夕颜花) - Evening glory flowers, often associated with wood magic